

The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Arthur Conan Doyle · 1892

First published: The Strand, Feb 1892

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Adventures_of_Sherlock_Holmes_(1892,_US)/The_Adventure_of_the_Speckled_Band (revision 15104245), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about reason and deduction?
- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about greed and violence?
- What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggest about protection of the vulnerable?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Adventure of the Speckled Band	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*reason and deduction* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Author biography

Arthur Conan Doyle was born in Edinburgh on 22 May 1859, studied medicine at the University of Edinburgh, where his teacher Dr. Joseph Bell's powers of observation inspired Sherlock Holmes, and practised as a doctor in Southsea. Holmes first appeared in A Study in Scarlet (1887); the stories in The Strand Magazine from 1891 made him world-famous. Doyle also wrote historical stories and science fiction, served as a volunteer doctor in the Boer War, was knighted in 1902, and in later life became a passionate Spiritualist. He died on 7 July 1930.

Historical and cultural context

Victorian England combined new forensic science with fascination with the Empire, especially India. The story's villain is a doctor who practised in Calcutta and keeps exotic animals.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Strand Magazine in February 1892; collected in The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes (1892).

Then: Very popular; Doyle later named it his favourite Holmes story.

Now: A model locked-room mystery for teaching inference and clues.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Helen Stoner comes to Holmes in terror: her twin sister died mysteriously two years earlier, crying out about "the speckled band," and now Helen hears the same strange whistle at night.

Main themes

- deduction and reason.
- greed.
- violence recoils on the violent.

Why it matters

Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.

Spoilers · teacher only

Holmes finds that the stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, sent a venomous snake through a ventilator to kill the sisters for their inheritance; the snake turns on Roylott and kills him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Adventure of the Speckled Band: What clues can you tell about a person from their appearance?
Prompt: Before we open The Adventure of the Speckled Band: What clues can you tell about a person from their appearance?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

locked-room mystery; red herring; clue; foreshadowing; deduction.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Arthur Conan Doyle was born in Edinburgh on 22 May 1859, studied medicine at the University of Edinburgh, where his teacher Dr. Joseph Bell's powers of observation inspired Sherlock Holmes, and practised as a doctor in Southsea. Holmes first appeared in A Study in Scarlet (1887); the stories in The Strand Magazine from 1891 made him world-famous. Doyle also wrote historical stories and science fiction, served as a volunteer doctor in the Boer War, was knighted in 1902, and in later life became a passionate Spiritualist. He died on 7 July 1930. The world of the book. Victorian England combined new forensic science with fascination with the Empire, especially India. The story's villain is a doctor who practised in Calcutta and keeps exotic animals. Publication and reception. First published in The Strand Magazine in February 1892; collected in The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes (1892). Then: Very popular; Doyle later named it his favourite Holmes story. Now: A model locked-room mystery for teaching inference and clues.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Helen's first words.

> *It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11)*

Think-aloud: "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Helen's first words.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Helen Stoner comes to Holmes in terror: her twin sister died mysteriously two years earlier, crying out about "the speckled band," and now Helen hears the same strange whistle at night. Themes to track: deduction and reason.: greed.: violence recoils on the violent.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Adventure of the Speckled Band: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Adventure of the Speckled Band still matter? Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.
Anchor question: Why might The Adventure of the Speckled Band still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students practise inference and learn how mysteries plant clues fairly.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Name two clues that point to the snake. Answer: The bell-rope that does not ring, the ventilator, the saucer of milk, the whistle, the bed clamped to the floor.
Exit ticket: Name two clues that point to the snake.
Answer: The bell-rope that does not ring, the ventilator, the saucer of milk, the whistle, the bed clamped to the floor.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Adventure of the Speckled Band.

Teacher notes · sources: Arthur Conan Doyle Encyclopedia (https://www.arthur-conan-doyle.com/); Britannica, "Sir Arthur Conan Doyle" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Arthur-Conan-Doyle); Arthur Conan Doyle Encyclopedia (https://www.arthur-conan-doyle.com/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Note for teachers: the "swamp adder" is not a real species; real snakes cannot hear whistles or climb ropes as described.

Lesson 2: The Adventure of the Speckled Band

Focus: reason defeating a hidden crime

Content note (murder, domestic abuse implied): Sensitive content: Murder; domestic abuse implied. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes murder; domestic abuse implied.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They wait in the dark; Holmes strikes at a swamp adder sent through the ventilator. The snake turns and kills Roylott, who had wanted the girls' inheritance.

Background: Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction.

Significance: Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to violence recoils on the violent because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes murder; domestic abuse implied.
Prompt: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to violence recoils on the violent because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: pittance — an inadequate payment; protruding — extend out or project in space; bequeathed — leave or give by will after one's death; bedrooms — a room used primarily for sleeping; impassable — incapable of being passed.
Words: pittance: an inadequate payment · protruding: extend out or project in space · bequeathed: leave or give by will after one's death · bedrooms: a room used primarily for sleeping · impassable: incapable of being passed

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction. Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference. Plot: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution. Foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Watch for the speckled band: a misleading clue (Gypsies' scarves) that turns out to be a snake.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Atmosphere. That is plot at work: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

> *It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror* *(The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11). Atmosphere. That is plot at work: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The repeated cry "The band! the speckled band" misleads at first; its meaning is revealed only at the end. Ask: How does this line connect to violence recoils on the violent? Expected: Roylott dies by his own weapon. (The clue.)

> *the band! The speckled band* *(The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The repeated cry "The band! the speckled band" misleads at first; its meaning is revealed only at the end.
Ask: How does this line connect to violence recoils on the violent?
Expected answer: Roylott dies by his own weapon. (The clue.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for plot, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. When the text says "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245), it shows this directly. Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."
Task: Annotate the story for plot, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. When the text says "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245), it shows this directly. Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible? Ask: does Holmes bear any responsibility for Roylott's death?
Anchor question: How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
Facilitation: Ask: does Holmes bear any responsibility for Roylott's death?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. ("Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent", The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. ("Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent", The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes reason defeating a hidden crime. Key takeaway: Roylott dies by his own weapon.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution.
- **Foreshadowing:** The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early.
- **Characterization:** Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm.

Themes and how they develop

- **violence recoils on the violent:** Roylott dies by his own weapon.

Symbols and motifs

- **the speckled band:** a misleading clue (Gypsies' scarves) that turns out to be a snake.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11) Atmosphere.
- "the band! The speckled band" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50) The clue.
- "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245) The moral.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created.
Evidence: "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245)
Reasoning: Holmes drives the snake back, and it kills Roylott; Holmes concludes, "Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
pittance (noun)	an inadequate payment	*It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
protruding (verb)	extend out or project in space	*Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bequeathed (verb)	leave or give by will after one's death	*She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

bedrooms (noun)	a room used primarily for sleeping	*The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
impassable (adjective)	incapable of being passed	*"Yet if the lady is correct in saying that the flooring and walls are sound, and that the door, window, and chimney are impassable, then her sister must have been undoubtedly alone when she met her mysterious end."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
revolved (verb)	turn on or around an axis or a center	*As I ran down the passage, my sister's door was unlocked, and revolved slowly upon its hinges.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*In a fit of anger, however, caused by some robberies which had been perpetrated in the house, he beat his native butler to death, and narrowly escaped a capital sentence.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
coincidence (noun)	an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental	*"Well, there is at least a curious coincidence of dates.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
headache (noun)	a pain in the head	*"You must confine yourself to your room, on pretence of a headache, when your step-father comes back.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
fireplace (noun)	an open recess in a wall at the base of a chimney where a fire can be built	*"See that you keep yourself out of my grip," he snarled, and hurling the twisted poker into the fireplace, he strode out of the room.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?
2. Where does foreshadowing appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with reason and deduction?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who comes to Holmes for help? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Helen Stoner
2. What were Julia's last words? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: It was the band! The speckled band!

3. What strange detail does Holmes find in the room? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
4. What is the 'speckled band'? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A swamp adder
5. What was Roylott's motive? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Adventure of the Speckled Band" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They wait in the dark; Holmes strikes at a swamp adder sent through the ventilator. The snake turns and…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Adventure of the Speckled Band"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Adventure of the Speckled Band" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent." What does "pittance" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: pittance: an inadequate payment.
10. Reread: "Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers." What does "protruding" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: protruding: extend out or project in space.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Adventure of the Speckled Band" suggest about reason defeating a hidden crime? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.
2. Find one example of foreshadowing in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
3. How does the point of view in this story shape what we understand about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: "It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror" (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins ""It is easy for me to be so, for every event of that dreadful time is seared into my memory.", why might Doyle have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.

5. What causes the main turn in “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Helen Stoner fears for her life: her twin sister Julia died two years before, crying 'It was the band! The speckled band!' Now her violent stepfather, Dr. Grimesby Roylott, has moved her into Julia's room. Holmes and Watson notice a dummy bell-rope, a ventilator and a bed bolted to the floor. They…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” set up that the rest of The Adventure of the Speckled Band will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. On characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do you figure out the truth when the facts seem impossible?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with reason and deduction? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On plot: Classic structure: client's story, investigation, night watch, solution. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in The Strand in February 1892. Doyle's Holmes popularized deductive detective fiction. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Doyle's own favorite Holmes story and a staple for teaching clues and inference.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On characterization: Roylott's violent temper (he bends a poker) contrasts with Holmes's calm. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to greed and violence: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Doyle need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the foreshadowing in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. On foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Adventure of the Speckled Band” treats reason defeating a hidden crime with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Adventure of the Speckled Band see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful

evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve reason and deduction? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “It is fear, Mr. Holmes. It is terror” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 11): Atmosphere. On foreshadowing: The ventilator, the bell-rope and the milk are planted early. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about reason defeating a hidden crime? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “the band! The speckled band” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 50): The clue. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Arthur Conan Doyle about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Roylott is destroyed by the weapon he created. Useful evidence: “Violence does, in truth, recoil upon the violent” (The Adventure of the Speckled Band, paragraph 245): The moral. Theme link: Roylott dies by his own weapon. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Foreshadowing:** look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. Who comes to Holmes for help?
   A. Helen Stoner
   B. Dr. Roylott
   C. Julia Stoner
   D. Mrs. Hudson
2. What were Julia's last words?
   A. It was the band! The speckled band!
   B. The gypsies!
   C. The doctor did it

D. Help me, Helen!

3. What strange detail does Holmes find in the room?
   A. A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
   B. A bloody knife
   C. A broken window
   D. A hidden door
4. What is the 'speckled band'?
   A. A necklace
   B. A gypsy scarf
   C. A ribbon
   D. A swamp adder
5. What was Roylott's motive?
   A. Jealousy
   B. Madness
   C. Revenge
   D. To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance
6. In the line “It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.”, what does “pittance” most nearly mean?
   A. a room used primarily for sleeping
   B. leave or give by will after one's death
   C. extend out or project in space
   D. an inadequate payment
7. In the line “Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.”, what does “protruding” most nearly mean?
   A. an inadequate payment
   B. leave or give by will after one's death
   C. extend out or project in space
   D. a room used primarily for sleeping

Answer key: 1. A (Helen Stoner); 2. A (It was the band! The speckled band!); 3. A (A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor); 4. D (A swamp adder); 5. D (To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance); 6. D (an inadequate payment); 7. C (extend out or project in space)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Adventure of the Speckled Band,” how does Doyle show reason defeating a hidden crime? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the foreshadowing you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In The Adventure of the Speckled Band, how does Doyle develop the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the foreshadowing in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Adventure of the Speckled Band develops the idea of reason defeating a hidden crime. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (where it begins, turns and ends) and its foreshadowing shape the reader's understanding of reason defeating a hidden crime. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Adventure of the Speckled Band suggests about reason defeating a hidden crime. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's foreshadowing and point of view), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Arthur Conan Doyle uses foreshadowing in The Adventure of the Speckled Band to complicate the reader's understanding of reason defeating a hidden crime. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Adventure of the Speckled Band within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of reason defeating a hidden crime responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Adventure of the Speckled Band alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of reason defeating a hidden crime follows or bends those conventions, using the foreshadowing as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Adventure of the Speckled Band and its treatment of reason defeating a hidden crime. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's foreshadowing and point of view, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Adventure of the Speckled Band as evidence for a larger claim about reason defeating a hidden crime in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Adventure of the Speckled Band as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of reason defeating a

hidden crime. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Adventure of the Speckled Band.

SAT-style questions

1. *She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bequeathed” most nearly mean?

   A. an open recess in a wall at the base of a chimney where a fire can be built

   B. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental

   C. leave or give by will after one's death

   D. a pain in the head

2. *"It is easy for me to be so, for every event of that dreadful time is seared into my memory. The manor-house is, as I have already said, very old, and only one wing is now inhabited. The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings. Of these bedrooms the first is Dr. Roylott's, the second my sister's, and the third my own. There is no communication between them, but they all open out into the same corridor. Do I make myself plain?"*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Adventure of the Speckled Band”?

   A. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

   B. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

   C. Superstition used against a credulous man

   D. Reason defeating a hidden crime

SAT key: 1. C (leave or give by will after one's death); 2. D (Reason defeating a hidden crime)

Whole-book test

The Adventure of the Speckled Band: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who comes to Holmes for help?
   A. Helen Stoner
   B. Dr. Roylott
   C. Julia Stoner
   D. Mrs. Hudson
2. What were Julia's last words?
   A. It was the band! The speckled band!
   B. The gypsies!
   C. The doctor did it
   D. Help me, Helen!
3. What strange detail does Holmes find in the room?
   A. A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor
   B. A bloody knife
   C. A broken window
   D. A hidden door
4. What is the 'speckled band'?
   A. A necklace
   B. A gypsy scarf
   C. A ribbon
   D. A swamp adder
5. What was Roylott's motive?
   A. Jealousy
   B. Madness
   C. Revenge
   D. To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance
6. In the line “It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple him to a very serious extent.”, what does “pittance” most nearly mean?
   A. a room used primarily for sleeping
   B. leave or give by will after one's death
   C. extend out or project in space
   D. an inadequate payment

7. In the line “Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slippers.”, what does “protruding” most nearly mean?
   A. an inadequate payment
   B. leave or give by will after one's death
   C. extend out or project in space
   D. a room used primarily for sleeping
8. As used in the story (“It is evident, therefore, that if both girls had married, this beauty would have had a mere pittance, while even one of them would cripple h”), what does “pittance” mean?
   A. an inadequate payment
   B. incapable of being passed
   C. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
   D. extend out or project in space
9. As used in the story (“Grimesby Roylott, clad in a long gray dressing-gown, his bare ankles protruding beneath, and his feet thrust into red heelless Turkish slipp”), what does “protruding” mean?
   A. turn on or around an axis or a center
   B. extend out or project in space
   C. a pain in the head
   D. leave or give by will after one's death
10. As used in the story (“She had a considerable sum of money—not less than £1000 a year—and this she bequeathed to Dr.”), what does “bequeathed” mean?
    A. closely; carefully
    B. an open recess in a wall at the base of a chimney where a fire can be built
    C. leave or give by will after one's death
    D. a room used primarily for sleeping
11. As used in the story (“The bedrooms in this wing are on the ground floor, the sitting-rooms being in the central block of the buildings.”), what does “bedrooms” mean?
    A. an event that might have been arranged although it was really accidental
    B. an inadequate payment
    C. incapable of being passed
    D. a room used primarily for sleeping
12. As used in the story (“"Yet if the lady is correct in saying that the flooring and walls are sound, and that the door, window, and chimney are impassable, then her”), what does “impassable” mean?
    A. incapable of being passed
    B. a pain in the head
    C. extend out or project in space
    D. turn on or around an axis or a center

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how reason and deduction develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how greed and violence develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how protection of the vulnerable develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (reason and deduction, greed and violence, protection of the vulnerable) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (Helen Stoner); 2. A (It was the band! The speckled band!); 3. A (A dummy bell-rope by a ventilator and a bed clamped to the floor); 4. D (A swamp adder); 5. D (To keep the stepdaughters' inheritance); 6. D (an inadequate payment); 7. C (extend out or project in space); 8. A (an inadequate payment); 9. B (extend out or project in space); 10. C (leave or give by will after one's death); 11. D (a room used primarily for sleeping); 12. A (incapable of being passed)

Essay assignments

Essay: Reason and deduction

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about reason and deduction. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops reason and deduction across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of reason and deduction. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of reason and deduction, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of reason and deduction in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band,

engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on reason and deduction in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Greed and violence

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about greed and violence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops greed and violence across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed and violence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed and violence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of greed and violence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed and violence in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Protection of the vulnerable

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Adventure of the Speckled Band teaches about protection of the vulnerable. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Arthur Conan Doyle develops protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Arthur Conan Doyle develops protection of the vulnerable across The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Adventure of the Speckled Band (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of protection of the vulnerable. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Arthur Conan Doyle's choices in The Adventure of the Speckled Band (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of protection of the vulnerable, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Adventure of the Speckled Band's treatment of protection of the vulnerable in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on protection of the vulnerable in The Adventure of the Speckled Band, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.